

DECISION QUALITY AND AFTER-ACTION LEARNING

Document ID: SH-GOV-LEARN-001 | **Version:** 1.0.0 | **Effective:** September 2, 2026 | **State:** LOCKED

Owner: Corporate Governance / J2 Education | **Related:** AAR, Orientation, Canon, risk assumption | **Cross-reference:** ../j2/EDUCATION.md; ../j2/ORIENTATION.md

Decision quality under uncertainty

A good decision can lose and a bad decision can get lucky. Sable Harbor does not evaluate judgment by outcome alone. Review asks:

1. Was ex-ante reasoning competent given what was knowable?
2. Was evidence gathered appropriately?
3. Were assumptions, confidence, and unknowns visible?
4. Was contrary evidence seriously considered?
5. Were applicable boundaries and controls followed?
6. What did reality teach afterward?

Authority does not automatically contract because a competent probabilistic decision produced a bad result. It may contract where evidence shows poor judgment, concealed assumptions, boundary failure, refusal to learn, or exposure beyond competence. Meanwhile the system changes when reality reveals a missing variable, altered market, bad model, or previously unknowable factor.

Learning practices

Hot washes capture immediate observations while memory and artifacts are fresh. AARs and postmortems reconstruct intent, predictions, evidence, actions, outcomes, and surprise. Forecast accountability compares what people expected with reality without turning probabilistic work into a scorekeeping trap. Lessons are explicit and identify which question, assumption, model, control, training, or envelope changes.

An AAR is not complete because a meeting occurred or a report exists. Learning closes when the relevant institutional representation changes—or when accountable leadership explicitly records why no change is warranted. J2 Orientation determines when an important lesson should enter enterprise questions, Canon, EIB, or Education through the appropriate human-authored processes.

Cultural posture

Sable Harbor is slow to condemn, slow to fire solely for variance, and slow to contract authority without evidence of judgment failure. It is fast to examine, fast to course-correct, and relentless about learning.

Challenge is hard on ideas and evidence and never demeaning to people. Respect is non-negotiable. Rank provides no immunity; candor does not authorize humiliation. A “roast culture” that makes people hide bad news is a control failure.

This philosophy should inform later recruiting, selection, promotion, development, education, and leadership evaluation. Those detailed talent systems remain future work and are not invented here.

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